

Conclusion

In the last eight chapters, I have made the case for ethical intuitionism by rebutting the alternative theories and then responding to all the major objections to intuitionism. In essence, I have argued:

1. There are five broad views about the nature of morality: non-cognitivism, subjectivism, naturalism, nihilism, and intuitionism.
2. Non-cognitivism, subjectivism, naturalism, and nihilism all face grave difficulties.
3. Intuitionism faces no serious problems.
4. Therefore, intuitionism is probably the correct view.

But the arguments establishing points (2) and (3) have been long and complex. In this chapter, I provide a brief review of the most important arguments for these theses. I then discuss why intuitionism has been unpopular, and why the issue is important. I conclude with some remarks about how I became an intuitionist.

9.1 The failures of alternative theories of metaethics

The four alternative theories of metaethics are competing views about the nature of values and value judgments. For ease of exposition, I shall give examples of what they would say about certain evaluative statements; in each case, it is to be understood that the theory says analogous things about all other evaluative statements.

9.1.1 Non-cognitivism

Ethical non-cognitivists say that 'x is wrong' does not assert anything that can be true or false. Instead, it just expresses an emotion or issues an imperative. It is thus comparable to 'Boo on x!' or 'Don't do x!'

There is no linguistic evidence to support this. Every objective test that anyone has come up with for distinguishing assertions from imperatives or expressions of emotion gives the result that 'x is wrong' is an assertion. Thus, consider the sentences (and pseudo-sentences) in the following table:

<i>Normal Sentence</i>	<i>Non-Cognitivist Interpretations</i>	
Abortion is wrong.	Boo on abortion.	Don't have an abortion.
It is false that abortion is wrong.	It is false that boo on abortion.	It is false that don't have an abortion.
Abortion may be wrong.	Maybe boo on abortion.	Maybe don't have an abortion.
Jon believes abortion is wrong.	Jon believes boo on abortion.	Jon believes don't have an abortion.
I hope abortion isn't wrong.	I hope not boo on abortion.	I hope not don't have an abortion.
Is abortion wrong?	Boo on abortion?	Don't have an abortion?
If abortion is wrong, then don't do it.	If boo on abortion, then don't do it.	If don't have an abortion, then don't do it.
The wrongness of abortion bothers me.	The boo-ness of abortion bothers me.	The don't-have-one-ness of abortion bothers me.

All the sentences in the first column make perfect sense and are good English. The second and third columns give attempted non-cognitivist interpretations of them. The only ones that even remotely appear to work are those in the first row. For any more complex sentence involving 'wrong', the non-cognitivist interpretation degenerates into nonsense. Not only are the expressions in the second and third columns grammatically malformed, but they fail to suggest any

intelligible meanings. I have no idea, for example, what it would mean to call an emotion 'false', nor what it would mean to believe an imperative. Furthermore, for any uncontroversial case of a non-cognitive sentence—such as 'Hurray for the Broncos!' or 'Please pass the salt'—no such problems arise; we do not call them false, say we believe them, and so on.

There is little psychological evidence to support non-cognitivism either. The non-cognitivist can point to the fact that emotions often accompany and even cause our moral judgments. But this is equally true of many non-moral, factual judgments, such as people's beliefs about their own intelligence, their beliefs about who 'really won' the 2000 U.S. Presidential election, and so on. Furthermore, the strength of our emotions bears little relationship to our moral beliefs. You can know that Nero's execution of Agrippina was far more wrong than your roommate's eating of your ice cream, but still feel more outrage at the latter than at the former. You may indeed feel nothing at all about Agrippina's fate.

Introspectively, we are aware of making moral *judgments*, which have the characteristics judgments normally do. One can distinguish, for example, the degree of confidence of one's belief from the degree of wrongness one believes an action to have. One might tentatively believe that abortion is very wrong, or firmly believe that abortion is slightly wrong, and these would be different states of mind. But if a moral 'judgment' were just an emotion or desire, no such distinction could exist; there would only be the strength of the emotion or desire one felt about abortion.

We treat the things we call 'moral judgments' in exactly the way we treat judgments, rather than the way we treat typical emotions or desires. We may exercise care in making moral judgments, wonder whether we are right, argue and weigh evidence about them, do research, and so on. We may consider arguments directed at whether our judgments are biased and whether they cohere with other plausible judgments. We do none of these things for typical emotions or desires.

All of the reasonably direct and objective evidence is against non-cognitivism—moral claims and judgments act in every discernible way just like assertions and beliefs. The only thing the non-cognitivist has going for him is the supposed implausibility of other views.

9.1.2 Subjectivism

Ethical subjectivists say that 'x is right' is a statement about someone's attitude towards x. Here are three common versions of subjectivism:

Individual Subjectivism: x is right = I (the speaker) approve of x .

Cultural Relativism: x is right = Society approves of x .

Divine Command Theory: x is right = God approves of x .

These theories face a host of problems. First, each implies that if the specified individual or group were to change their attitudes, then seemingly horrible things would suddenly become moral. Thus, each theory entails a statement of the following form:

If (I/society/God) were to approve of torturing and killing children for the fun of it, then it would be right to torture and kill children for the fun of it.

But this is not correct.

Second, individual subjectivism implies, absurdly, that I am morally infallible: that in general, if I approve of something then, automatically, it is morally correct. Cultural relativism similarly implies that society is morally infallible.

Third, these theories make moral disagreement difficult to understand. On the individual subjectivist view, A could disagree with B 's statement, ' x is wrong', only if A doubted that B was truthfully reporting B 's attitudes. On the cultural relativist view, the disagreement could only occur if the parties disagreed about what the attitudes of most of society were, and it would be impossible for anyone to criticize the prevailing social norms. On the divine command theory, moral disagreements would have to be disagreements about God's commands, and atheists and agnostics thus could not have moral views.¹

Fourth, these theories all imply that a merely arbitrary attitude or decision can render an action obligatory. All of them imply that there are no evaluative facts independent of the attitudes of the specified individual or group. Therefore, the specified individual or group can not approve of the things they approve of *because* they are right, good, or have any other positive characteristic. Thus, these attitudes of approval would have to be arbitrary. But how would someone's *arbitrarily* approving of x make it right to do x ?

Fifth, the divine command theory faces the additional problems of how we can know either that God exists, or what He wants if He does.

On top of this, there are no good arguments for subjectivism. The main arguments seem to consist in pointing out either that people have many conflicting moral beliefs or that many people form moral beliefs in irrational ways. It is obscure how either of these things

could support subjectivism. The arguments make about as much sense as arguing that if three gamblers all believe, for emotional reasons, that different horses are going to win a race, then the race won't have any outcome in reality, or it will have different outcomes 'relative' to different people.

9.1.3 Naturalism

Ethical Naturalists hold two beliefs:

- i) Moral properties are *reducible*: for instance, it is possible to explain what wrongness is without using any evaluative expressions. There are two variants of this idea:
 - a) *Analytic* reductionists say that some expression containing no evaluative terms is *synonymous* with 'wrong'.
 - b) *Synthetic* reductionists say that some expression containing no evaluative terms explains *what it is* to be wrong, even though it does not have the same meaning as 'wrong'.
- ii) Moral truths can be known, ultimately, on the basis of observation.

Analytic reductionism was refuted by G. E. Moore. If two expressions have the same meaning, then it should be possible to substitute one expression for the other in any sentence, without changing the meaning of the sentence. Moore noticed that for any non-evaluative expression, it was possible to formulate a meaningful statement or question containing the word 'good' in which, intuitively, one *cannot* substitute the non-evaluative expression for 'good'. Thus, consider the three reductionist theories mentioned below:

<i>Reductionist Definition</i>	<i>Moorean Question</i>	<i>Reductionist Interpretation</i>
<i>x is good = x promotes pleasure.</i>	Is pleasure good?	Does pleasure promote pleasure?
<i>x is right = x accords with social customs.</i>	Is it right to obey social customs?	Does obeying social customs accord with social customs?
<i>x is good = x promotes life.</i>	Is life good?	Does life promote itself?

In the first column are three examples of analytic reductionist theses. In the second column are questions that it makes sense to ask, in

ordinary moral discourse. The Moorean point is that the questions in the third column obviously do not mean the same as those in the second column. But they should mean the same, if the reductionist theories were correct. So the reductionist theories are not correct accounts of the meanings of 'good' or 'right'.

Synthetic reductionists grant this point. They say that moral properties are reducible in a way analogous to how *water*, for example, is reducible: water is H_2O ; however, the word 'water' is not *synonymous* with the word ' H_2O '. This can be shown by a Moorean argument: the question, 'What is the chemical formula of water?' does not mean the same as, 'What is the chemical formula of H_2O ?'; therefore, 'water' does not mean the same as ' H_2O '. Nevertheless, H_2O is what water is.

This form of reductionism faces two main problems. The first is that evaluative properties seem, on their face, to be radically different in kind from natural properties. Being good, for instance, is obviously a different kind of thing from being round, weighing 200 pounds, or being positively charged. This can be seen on the basis of one's grasp of the concepts of the relevant properties, just as one can see, solely on the basis of one's understanding of the concept of a symphony and the concept of a planet, that the planet Neptune is not Beethoven's Ninth Symphony.

The second problem is that synthetic reductionists cannot explain moral knowledge. We do not know about wrongness in the way we know about water—we cannot observe with the five senses that an act is wrong. Nor, according to the synthetic reductionists, can we know that an act is wrong by intuition. Nor can one deduce evaluative propositions from non-evaluative premises.

Contemporary naturalists commonly argue that we can know moral truths because some moral truths provide the best explanations for certain non-moral facts of which we have independent knowledge. For instance, Adolf Hitler's evilness supposedly provides the best explanation for why he ordered the Final Solution. But in order for this to work as an account of our moral knowledge, the naturalist would have to show that the hypothesis that Hitler was evil enables us to explain facts that *could not otherwise be explained*, and to do so without relying on any *ad hoc* assumptions about the causal powers of evil or the like. Thus, one would have to argue that Hitler's actions could not be explained as well by appealing merely to psychological facts non-morally described, such as the fact that he had an intense hatred for Jews, a lust for power, and so on. Naturalists have failed to make this case.

Another way of seeing the futility of the naturalist's project is to

imagine a perverse individual with exactly opposite values to your own. This person could construct 'explanations' for observed phenomena exactly parallel to any that you could construct, but using 'bad' wherever you use 'good', and so on. Thus, if you say that Hitler's actions during World War II were explained by his evilness, the perverse individual could say that Hitler's actions were explained by his goodness. If you say that slavery was abolished because it was unjust (and people generally tend to oppose injustice), the perverse individual could say that slavery was abolished because it was just (and people generally tend to oppose justice). No doubt we would accuse this perverse person of holding corrupt values, but this could not be proven merely by citing the ability to explain observed facts, since he could offer explanations corresponding to every explanation we offered. His explanations, of course, would be counter-intuitive, but the ethical naturalist does not recognize intuition as a legitimate source of knowledge. Consequently, the naturalist would have no way of showing any given moral belief to be more justified than its exact opposite.

9.1.4 Nihilism

Nihilists believe that all positive evaluative claims are false. They believe this because they think that (a) evaluative claims are claims about an alleged realm of non-natural, objective moral properties, but (b) there really are no such properties. Abortion, the nihilist would say, cannot be wrong, because in order for it to be wrong there would have to be such things as objective values.

This view has such implications as the following: murder is not wrong; the most excruciating pain is not worse than the greatest ecstasy; the Holocaust was not bad; and so on. It is difficult to know how to respond to such a view, because it is difficult to think of any propositions more absurd than some of those that its proponents explicitly embrace.

In order to support their view, nihilists must bring forward powerful arguments. These arguments would have to start from premises that we are strongly convinced of—in particular, these premises would have to be more plausible than the claim that murder is wrong, that the Holocaust was bad, and so on. It is difficult to see how the nihilist could do this.

The actual arguments brought forth by nihilists have been disappointing. They depend upon the supposed implausibility of the notion of objective morality. But the notion of objective morality is not implausible, and the arguments against it have been rebutted in earlier chapters.

9.2 The intuitionist view

We have established so far:

1. Evaluative statements assert propositions, which can be true or false. (Non-cognitivism is false.)
2. They are not always false. (Nihilism is false.)
3. The truth of an evaluative statement is not subjective or relative. (Subjectivism is false.)
4. Evaluative facts cannot be reduced to non-evaluative facts, nor can they be known solely on the basis of observation. (Naturalism is false.)

From these points, it follows that:

5. Some evaluative statements are true. (From 1, 2.)
6. Some evaluative statements are objectively true. (From 3, 5.)
7. There are irreducible, objective, evaluative facts, which cannot be known on the basis of observation. (From 4, 6.)²

(7) is close to a definition of ethical intuitionism. It lacks only a positive statement of how evaluative facts are known, to which we now turn.

9.2.1 Intuition and moral knowledge

Some basic principles about good, bad, right, and wrong are self-evident, such as the following:

Suffering is bad.

If *A* is better than *B* and *B* is better than *C*, then *A* is better than *C*.

If an action is wrong, then any qualitatively indistinguishable action (in identical circumstances) is also wrong.

No person is blameworthy for an action they did not perform.

These principles are self-evident in the same sense that the following are:

Nothing is both red and green.

If *A* is next to *B*, then *B* is next to *A*.

Yellow is a color.

Everything is identical with itself.

'Socrates is a man' and 'All men are inconsiderate' together entail
'Socrates is inconsiderate'.
Time is one-dimensional.
Seven is more than two.

We are justified in believing these propositions for the same reason that we are justified in believing observations of the external world: namely, because they seem to be the case and we have no serious grounds for doubting them. The principle of *Phenomenal Conservatism* states: if it seems to one that *p*, then one has at least *prima facie* justification for believing that *p*. This principle is presupposed in all normal judgment and reasoning, since the judgments one makes are determined by what seems to oneself to be the case. What arguments a person accepts is also a matter of what arguments seem to him to be valid and to have true premises. Even skeptics who say that we know nothing say this only because it seems to them to be the case (or seems to follow from things that seem to them to be the case).

We form justified beliefs about the physical world on the basis of sensory appearances (also called 'perceptual experiences'). Similarly, we form justified beliefs about certain abstract truths, including the self-evident principles mentioned above, on the basis of *intellectual* appearances ('intuitions'). Intuitions are mental states in which something appears to be the case upon intellectual reflection (as opposed to perception, memory, or introspection), prior to argument.

When we perceive physical objects, we do not first apprehend perceptual experiences and then *infer* that there are physical objects corresponding to them. Instead, we are first aware of physical objects, directly. Our perceptual experiences are merely the form that that awareness takes; they (partly) *constitute* our awareness of the physical world. Similarly, when we know moral truths intuitively, we do not first apprehend intuitions and then *infer* that there are moral facts corresponding to them. Instead, we are directly aware of moral facts. Our intuitions are merely the form that that awareness takes; they (partly) constitute our awareness of moral truths.

Moral intuitions can be affected by bias, just as nearly all beliefs can. However, moral intuitions are not moral *beliefs*, nor are they simply caused by our moral beliefs. This is shown by the fact that, when confronted with cases we have never previously considered, we often have moral intuitions that conflict with our moral theories. Thus, even utilitarians experience the intuition that it would be wrong to kill a healthy person to distribute his organs to five other people who need transplants, although utilitarians do not *believe* this

intuition. In some cases, we have difficulty even coming up with a theory that accommodates our intuitions.

9.2.2 Moral motivation

Why should we be moral? According to the most popular theory of practical reasons, the only *good reason*, as well as the only *motivation*, anyone can have for doing anything at all is that it would satisfy their desires. This is the Humean theory of reasons.

The Humean theory is too simplistic. There are at least two different kinds of motivation one can have: one can be motivated by desires, and one can be motivated by certain kinds of beliefs. The Humean is correct to note that *most* kinds of belief cannot by themselves motivate action. For example, my belief that I am out of cookies cannot by itself move me to buy more cookies at the store, since the belief that I am out of cookies does not by itself tell me whether having cookies is desirable or not. But there are some kinds of beliefs that are different, including prudential beliefs (beliefs about what is in one's interests) and moral beliefs. These beliefs *do*, by their very nature, tell us what is desirable and what is not. The belief that I am out of cookies may be unable to motivate action, but the belief that I am out of cookies *and* it would be *good* to have some cookies, can do so.

These evaluative beliefs render certain actions *prima facie* rational. The belief that *x* is in one's long-term interests provides one with a good reason for doing *x*. Furthermore, this reason takes precedence over any desires one may have to the contrary, in the sense that even if one *wants* more strongly to do something else, it would still be rational to do *x*. This is because the prudential belief (if formed rationally) already takes into account one's evaluation of the relative importance of one's present desires; thus, one's present desires cannot weigh against it. Similarly, the belief that *x* is morally required provides one with a good reason for doing *x*. This reason takes precedence not only over desires but also over prudential beliefs. This is because the moral belief (if formed rationally) already takes into account one's evaluation of the relative importance of one's desires and interests; thus, one's desires and interests cannot weigh against it.

But while prudential and moral beliefs have this kind of rational authority, people do not always act rationally: there are cases of weakness of the will, in which a person acts on some present desire rather than on his judgment of what is really in his interests, or of what is morally right. Weakness of will and strength of will are both possible, because the weight of rational motives for action is not

commensurable with the strength of desires—this is because a rational motive is a belief, and it does not make sense to ask whether a belief is ‘stronger’ or ‘weaker’ than a desire. This view at least leaves room for free will, something the Humean theory appears unable to do.

The Humean theory of reasons is inferior in a number of ways to the account just sketched. First, the Humean theory offers us no understanding of the phenomenon of weakness of will. On the Humean view, when two motives conflict, since all motives come from desire, the only question is: which desire is stronger? The stronger desire will always be acted upon. Furthermore, since all good reasons for action come from desire, it will be *rational* to act on the stronger desire. There is nothing in this story that resembles ‘weakness’, that explains how agents might act irrationally, or that explains the appropriateness of remorse or blame reactions.

Second, the Humean cannot explain what is interesting or particularly important about morality. On the Humean view, the most that could be said for morality is that its rules will often help us satisfy certain desires, such as our desires for the well-being of others. But we have many other desires that may conflict with moral motivation, such as the desires caused by envy, anger, and hatred; and from a Humean point of view, there is no reason why the former desires should be somehow privileged over the latter. Morality thus merely serves some arbitrarily selected subclass of our desires, which we have no more reason to take an interest in than in any other desires we happen to have. The rationalist, anti-Humean view avoids this problem by appealing to objective evaluative facts—the fact that actions prompted by envy and hatred are generally bad, for example.

Third, the Humean conception of reasons cannot accommodate paradigmatic examples of rational and irrational actions, declaring instead that *no* action can ever be irrational. For example, the Humean is forced to say that the following are examples of equally rational actions:

Odysseus: Odysseus knows that when he approaches the Sirens, he will feel an intense desire to join them, but he *now* desires that he not join them. Odysseus gives no weight to his future desire, and instead has himself tied to the mast so that he will be unable in the future to act on that desire.

The Partying Student: A student decides to spend the night partying, knowing that this will result in her failing an important test the next day. Though she knows that tomorrow she will wish she had spent the night studying, she gives little or no weight to this future desire, and instead acts on her immediate desire to party.

For a Humean, the reasons for action one *now* has must be determined by the desires one now has. The only reason one would care about one's future desires would be if one had a *present* desire that one's future desires be satisfied—but there is no reason why one must have such a present desire. The Humean is right about Odysseus' case: we can all agree that Odysseus is rational in acting to satisfy his present desire, rather than his future desire to be with the Sirens. But the Humean is just as clearly wrong about the Partying Student case: this is a paradigm case of irrational behavior. The rationalist has a ready explanation: Odysseus' future desire to be with the Sirens will be an irrational desire, because it will be a desire for what is clearly bad; the student's future desire to pass the test, however, will be a perfectly rational desire. Thus, it is rational for Odysseus to discount his future desire, but irrational for the student to do likewise. A Humean cannot accept this natural explanation, since Humeans deny that ultimate desires can be evaluated by reason.

Fourth, a Humean cannot even account for why we should care about making our moral judgments coherent. The usual reason for wanting coherent beliefs is that coherent beliefs are more likely to be true. But for a Humean, moral principles—to the extent that we have any reason to pay attention to them—must reflect our desires and feelings, rather than our beliefs. Desires differ fundamentally from beliefs in that, whereas we aim to make our beliefs conform to reality, we do not aim to make our desires conform to reality; instead, we aim to make *reality* conform to our *desires*. Thus, whereas I would be irrational to continue to hold a belief that has been shown to be unlikely to be true, I would not be to any extent irrational to have a desire that has been shown to be unlikely to be satisfied. For this reason, one cannot argue that we should seek to have coherent desires on the grounds that such desires are more likely to match reality. With no requirement of coherence on desires, we would be left also with no requirement of coherence on moral principles.

Despite its popularity, the Humean theory fails abysmally as an account of practical rationality: it misclassifies paradigm cases of irrational actions as rational; it collapses 'rational action' into whatever an agent actually chooses; and it cannot account for weakness of will, free will, or the importance of morality. The only justification typically offered for the Humean theory is an appeal to intuition—it just seems that only desires can motivate. But this intuition depends on our considering only certain kinds of cases. When we consider *evaluative* beliefs, it is not at all intuitively obvious that such beliefs cannot motivate.

9.3 Select objections to intuitionism

A variety of objections have been raised to ethical intuitionism. Following are the four most common.

9.3.1 'Intuition cannot be proven to be reliable'

Some say that we cannot know moral truths by means of intuition unless we can first verify that intuition in general is reliable. Those who make this objection would not be satisfied by the use of intuitions to support other intuitions—showing, in other words, that one has an internally coherent system of intuitions. Nor would they be satisfied by a showing that one's intuitions cohere with those of other people. Rather, the objectors seek a verification of the reliability of intuition that does not itself rely on anyone's intuition at any point.

No such verification can be produced. But this is not a problem, for at least two reasons. First, because no such verification exists for sense perception, memory, introspection, or reason in general, either. No one can prove that sense perception is generally reliable, using only non-perceptual evidence. No one can prove that memory is generally reliable, using only information gathered at the present instant in time. No one can prove reason to be reliable, without using reason. But we do not declare all of these forms of cognition illegitimate. To do so would land us in the pit of universal skepticism. It appears, then, that the present objection relies on an epistemological double-standard: the objector imposes demands on intuition that would not be placed on any other fundamental source of knowledge.

Second, the demand was never justified in the first place. Why should any process of cognition demand a second cognitive process directed at the first one? Why not instead hold, in accordance with the principle of Phenomenal Conservatism, that our cognitive faculties are presumed innocent until proven guilty? This avoids dogmatism by leaving us open to the possibility of revising our initial beliefs if new evidence should appear defeating them, but it also avoids the extreme skepticism that would never allow us any starting points at all for our belief systems.

The demand for verification of reliability would seem appropriate *if* we conceived intuition (and perception, memory, and so on) as giving us immediate awareness of mental states, from which we try to infer conclusions about the real world. Such an inference would require the prior assumption of a correlation between such mental states and states of the real world, an assumption which would

require justification. But as I have urged above, this would be a misunderstanding of the role of intuition; we should conceive of intuitions, like perceptual experiences and memory experiences, as merely vehicles of the awareness of facts that exist independent of them.

9.3.2 'Intuitionists cannot explain disagreement'

Some claim that intuitionism makes it impossible to understand how moral error and moral disagreement can occur. Those who press this objection often seem to have in mind an infallibilistic caricature of intuitionism that probably does not correspond to any actual intuitionist's views. Indeed, it is hard enough to find philosophers who claim infallibility about anything, let alone ethics.

Those who avoid unfairly caricaturing intuitionism argue simply that there is *more* error and disagreement than one would expect if intuitionism were true. There are at least four reasons why they are mistaken. First, they typically exaggerate the amount of disagreement and error that exists. While there is widespread disagreement about such issues as abortion, affirmative action, and capital punishment, there are no serious disputes about the desirability of such things as murder, rape, and armed robbery. The former sort of issues receive much more attention than the latter, simply because we don't normally discuss what everyone already knows. This leads to an exaggerated view of the prevalence of controversy.

Second, human error and disagreement are common with respect to many objective, factual questions. People sharply disagree about such things as who shot JFK, whether a particular basketball player is better than another, whether a particular individual is smarter than another, whether there is a God, and virtually every major issue in philosophy. Furthermore, throughout history, almost everyone who has held any views at all about them has held radically erroneous views about such things as: the causes of health and disease, the structure of the cosmos, the origin of the human species, the existence of disembodied spirits, the composition of the physical world, and the workings of the economy, to name a few. But no one concludes either that these matters are all 'subjective' or that human beings lack any legitimate cognitive faculties capable of knowing about them.

Third, in general, even when we have available a valid means of cognition, human beings are subject to a great variety of causes of error. These include bias, oversight, miscalculation, confusion, false or incomplete information, and logical fallacies, among others. It is a naive philosopher indeed who thinks that intellectual processes

nearly always run smoothly and cleanly, with no defects or non-rational influences. There is no obvious reason why the problems that lead to errors and disagreements about so many other things would not occur when people think about values. Here, as with the previous objection, an epistemological double-standard is being applied: almost no one takes the validity of other means of cognition, such as empirical reasoning, to be refuted by the existence of widespread errors and disagreements, nor by our susceptibility to mistakes and non-rational influences of various kinds. Only intuition is taken to be impugned by such facts. Of course, the facts *do* warrant our being *cautious* in our ethical claims, just as we should be cautious in our claims about the other matters of controversy mentioned above.

Fourth, if we consider what sorts of issues people generally disagree about the most and make the most errors about, it is easily predictable that moral matters would be among them. For people tend to disagree and make errors the most about (a) issues they are strongly biased about, including but not limited to those in which their own interests are at stake, (b) issues on which their beliefs are largely based on cultural indoctrination, (c) issues on which their beliefs are largely based on religion, and (d) philosophical issues in general. This is true regardless of whether the issues in question are evaluative. Since moral issues fall into all four of these categories, it is to be expected that disagreement and error would be common with respect to moral issues. Thus, there is nothing surprising in the phenomenon of moral disagreement that calls for an anti-realist interpretation.

9.3.3 'Intuitionists cannot resolve disagreements'

Some object that intuitionism gives us no reasonable method for resolving moral disagreements. The most initially plausible form of the objection claims that there are many differences of intuitions, and that intuitionists have no method for adjudicating between contrary intuitions.

This objection fails for several reasons. First, some ethical intuitions may cohere better or worse with the *rest* of our intuitions. Thus, moral philosophers commonly argue for positions on controversial moral issues by appealing to our intuitions about (allegedly) analogous cases. They also often appeal to intuitions about what sorts of factors may be morally relevant. These are just two of the ways in which other intuitions may be brought to bear on controversial ones.

Second, we can use our knowledge of the factors that tend to affect the reliability of people's beliefs to determine which intuitions are most likely to be correct. We may have reason to believe that

certain moral intuitions are unduly influenced by bias, indoctrination, religion, and so on. This is true, for example, of many moral attitudes pertaining to sexuality and reproduction.

Third, even if some moral disputes turn out to be unresolvable, it is obscure how this is supposed to refute intuitionism. There are many disputes, about both moral and non-moral matters, that appear for all practical purposes unresolvable. Why should we assume that, on the correct theory, all moral disputes would be resolvable? Once again, the objection to intuitionism rests on a double standard: for no other fundamental knowledge source do we demand an algorithm for resolving all disputes.

Fourth, the objection rests on another double standard: no other metaethical theory is typically subjected to the demand to provide a method of resolving all moral disputes—and no other metaethical theory can do so. Neither the non-cognitivists, nor the subjectivists, nor the naturalists have produced a method of securing agreement on the morality of abortion, capital punishment, and the like.

Finally, all versions of the ‘disagreement’ objection appear to be self-refuting. Those who give the objection claim that their objection itself, together with the metaethical conclusion that it supports, is objectively correct. Yet many intelligent people continue to disagree with the argument from disagreement, and with each metaethical theory. How can anti-realists or naturalists explain this disagreement? And how can they resolve it? The prospects for resolving this disagreement seem no better than the prospects for resolving the disagreement about the morality of abortion.

9.3.4 ‘Intuitionism is weird’

Many consider ethical intuitionism too ‘weird’ or ‘mysterious’ to be embraced. There are two parts to this criticism: (a) irreducible moral facts are a weird kind of fact; (b) intuition is a weird way of knowing.

It is unclear what this criticism amounts to. Is there an objective property of ‘weirdness’? If there are no objective values, then it is doubtful that there is objective weirdness either. But if there is not, then it is hard to see how the alleged weirdness of intuitionism would count as evidence against it. If, for example, ‘ x is weird’ just expresses a subjective reaction towards x , then it provides no argument against the reality of x .

If there is objective weirdness, what does it consist in? Consider three interpretations. First, perhaps ‘weird’ means ‘very different from most other things’. Moral facts are very different from other kinds of facts, and intuition is very different from other kinds of awareness. But how would this tend to show that either moral facts or moral

intuition doesn't exist? We live in a diverse world: there are *many* things we know of that are very different from each other.

Second, perhaps 'weird' means 'counter-intuitive'. But the existence of moral facts is not counter-intuitive. Ordinary moral discourse, in which we all engage on a daily basis, is committed to the existence of moral facts. And as my arguments against subjectivism show, and as is commonly accepted even among anti-realists, we ordinarily think of these facts as objective. It would be difficult to argue that it is the intuitionist who is taking a counter-intuitive position.

Third, perhaps 'weird' means 'poorly understood'. But again, we lack any clear reason for thinking that things which are weird in that sense do not exist. Nor is there any obvious reason for thinking that either moral properties or moral intuition is less well understood than many other things whose existence we accept, such as consciousness, numbers, dispositional properties, possibilities, time, space, fields, aesthetic properties, and propositions.

The argument from weirdness, then, is as obscure as it is influential. It is highly obscure what weirdness is, or how the charge of weirdness provides an objection to a theory. Intuitionism may well be a 'weird' position in some sense, but if it is, this does not appear to provide any evidence against its truth.

9.4 The revolt against values: how intuitionism lost favor

That concludes my official, philosophical case for ethical intuitionism. I am now going to indulge in psychological and sociological speculation about the resistance to ethical intuitionism. This speculation will not provide evidence for intuitionism; however, it may have some logical relevance, since it will suggest that most of those who have rejected intuitionism have formed their beliefs in an unreliable way.

9.4.1 Was intuitionism rationally refuted?

Ethical intuitionism was popular among English-speaking philosophers in the early twentieth century. By mid-century, it had suffered a dramatic loss of favor, continuing to the present day. Why? One account, congenial to the anti-realists, goes like this: 'Intuitionism was the first view of ethics that occurred to people, at the dawn of analytic philosophy, because it is the simplest, most naive view. Intuitionism is similar to Plato's view of ethics, which, not coinciden-

tally, arose at the dawn of Western philosophy. As people reflected more, they quickly noticed the various fatal flaws in the system and rationally rejected it in favor of more sophisticated and defensible theories'.

I suspect that is how many contemporary philosophers see that bit of intellectual history. But I think that is utter fantasy. In my view, the broad movements in the history of philosophy look much more like shifts in temperament and intellectual fashions than like rational movements away from unworkable theories towards more objectively defensible ones. I cannot support that judgment in a general way here, since it would call for a discussion of several major philosophical issues and episodes in the history of philosophy. But I can provide some support for the contention as it applies to ethical intuitionism and its fall from philosophical favor. Intuitionism was not rejected because it was found to be unworkable. It was rejected first, then the rejection was rationalized by a handful of paper-thin objections, including those discussed in the previous section. That this was what really happened is evidenced by two salient facts.

First, there is the fact that most of the prominent objections to intuitionism rest upon epistemological double-standards, making demands of intuition and intuitionism that would not be imposed on any other basic means of cognition, or on any other metaethical theory. This sort of reasoning is characteristic of rationalizations. And one of the main objections seems to rest on nothing more than a subjective sense of 'weirdness', which is difficult to distinguish from a mere bias.

Second, there is the fact that most, if not all of the objections to intuitionism are subject to rather simple and natural replies, requiring no significant modifications to the theory; yet the critics of intuitionism have devoted virtually no energy to considering such replies. In contrast, the more fashionable metaethical theories have been the subject of numerous elaborate, technical modifications and variations over a period of decades, designed to show how they can escape from the seemingly devastating objections that lie very close to the surface. In short, metaethicists over the past fifty years never gave ethical intuitionism anything like the serious consideration they devoted to other theories.

Of course, I deny that intuitionism was ever *refuted*, since I think the theory is true and that I have shown it to be true in the preceding pages of this book. But even if you think I am wrong about this, you should still agree that I have made a case for intuitionism that is about as reasonable, at least, as the case that has been made for some of the other theories in metaethics. But in the ethics literature over

the past fifty years, intuitionism has been taken far less seriously and given far less attention than any of the other four metaethical theories. So, whether or not intuitionism is actually true, it seems clear that the opposition to it has been out of proportion to any objective assessment of the weight of the arguments. Some other explanation for intuitionism's fall from favor is required.

I believe that intuitionism was rejected because it does not fit with the *spirit* of the modern age. There are at least three important tendencies of modern, Western culture that are relevant here: cynicism, political correctness, and scientism.

9.4.2 Cynicism

In the twentieth century, everything once held in high esteem—human nature, science, truth, objective knowledge, art, philosophy, religion, morality—had to be *debunked*. Psychologists sought to show that Man, once considered ‘the rational animal’, was fundamentally irrational. Freudians found us filled with lust and socially destructive impulses; Marxists found human history dominated by greed and exploitation; sociobiologists found all aspects of human life dominated by ‘selfish’ drives to reproduce. All three groups found human beings massively self-deceived and considered such supposedly spiritual pursuits as art, religion, and philosophy to be covers for something shallower and far less noble than they appear. Many have remarked on how tiny and insignificant humanity is, how foolish we once were to think ourselves the center of the universe, and how ignorant and helpless we are. Many philosophers, who had once seen their discipline as a rational pursuit of fundamental truths about the nature of reality and our place in it, now denied that philosophy could tell us anything of such truths, if such truths even existed. One influential school of thought declared that philosophers could do no more than discuss how people use words, and that metaphysics, theology, and ethics were all ‘meaningless’. Other philosophers declared that there is no such thing as truth, that we can never know it, that we are fundamentally irrational, and/or that objectivity is impossible. American intellectuals attacked what were once their country’s most revered forebears—such as Christopher Columbus, Thomas Jefferson, and George Washington—as hypocrites, bigots, and exploiters; they attacked the Declaration of Independence and the Constitution similarly. And Western intellectuals attacked Christianity more than any other religion. Modern thinkers have sought to tear down their own society’s heroes, its religion, its philosophy, its economic and political system—in short, its values.

I do not plan to explain all the intellectual developments

mentioned in the preceding paragraph; I rely on the reader's familiarity with contemporary intellectual culture to recognize most of what I have just mentioned. Nor do I plan to discuss their intellectual merits—in some cases, the attitudes may have been justified, while in others they were not. My point here is that, whatever else may be said about them, all those cultural developments have at least one thing in common: cynicism. Western culture of the past fifty years must be among the most cynical cultures in world history. And that thoroughgoing cynicism has made the widespread acceptance of ethical intuitionism impossible in our culture, whatever the intellectual merits of the theory. A culture that insists that humans are fundamentally selfish and ignoble will never accept my account of moral motivation. A culture that declares the notions of truth, knowledge, and objectivity delusory will never accept my account of moral knowledge. And a culture that seeks to tear down all values will never accept moral realism. Subjectivism, non-cognitivism, and nihilism have been popular, in short, because they offer the modern mind the perverse pleasure of debunking morality.

9.4.3 Political correctness

Political correctness has two, closely-related aspects: First, the imperative to avoid giving offense, even to the most sensitive individuals. Thus, we call garbage men 'sanitation engineers'. We call stupid people 'mentally challenged'. ('Retarded' was originally a euphemism for 'stupid', but it has since come to seem even more derogatory than 'stupid'; hence the need for a new euphemism.) What was once the vice of drunkenness has become the 'disease' of alcoholism. It is particularly *groups*, rather than individuals, that one must be wary of offending.

Second, political correctness entails an extreme egalitarianism. To be politically correct, one must avoid saying that anyone is better than anyone else in any significant way. This is a corollary to the first rule: to deny equality might give offense to those who are judged worse.

Moral realists seem to violate both of these strictures. If there are real moral requirements, then presumably not everyone is satisfying them: sometimes, people do wrong. Some people might even have to be judged *evil*, if they perpetrate sufficiently serious wrongs. In any case, if there are virtues and vices, then some people will surely turn out to have more virtues and fewer vices than others: won't we then have to call these people 'morally better' than the others? But to say such a thing would surely offend those judged to be worse. Indeed,

there are few more reliable ways of offending a person than calling him immoral.

Furthermore, if there are objective facts of any kind, then some *beliefs*—those that correspond to the facts—are presumably better than others. But again, to say this would surely give offense to those who hold the ‘inferior’ (that is, false) beliefs. In view of this and the preceding point, it might turn out that some cultures are morally worse than others—for they might have false moral beliefs and engage in immoral practices. If we judge, for example, that men and women really have equal rights, would we not be forced to conclude that Islamic culture is bad in a very significant respect—it embraces false moral beliefs and treats women wrongly? To say such a thing would surely offend Muslims. But how could we avoid saying such things, if we believed in objective values? It seems that, to be politically correct, we must be anti-realists.

My purpose here is not to discuss Muslim culture, the nature of evil, alcoholism, and so on. My purpose is to explain the ascendance of moral anti-realism in modern times: the popularity of anti-realism, I believe, is in large part due to the perception that moral realism would force us into uncomfortable positions that would cause offense to certain groups.

9.4.4 Scientism

To explain what scientism is, I can hardly do better than to quote Peter van Inwagen:

Scientism, as I use the word, is a sort of exaggerated respect for science—that is, for the physical and biological sciences—and a corresponding disparagement of all other areas of human intellectual endeavour. It hardly need be pointed out that scientism is the primary ideology of our age. It hardly need be pointed out that the illusions scientism engenders are so pervasive and so insidious that it is practically impossible to get anyone who is subject to them to consider the possibility that they might be illusions.³

Modern science is an excellent thing: it has given us unprecedented understanding of the world and unprecedented ability to modify the world to satisfy our needs and desires. This does not mean that such non-scientific endeavors as art, literature, and philosophy have become less worthwhile, or that such ‘softer’ sciences as psychology and sociology are not important fields of knowledge. But the victims of scientism feel otherwise. Victims of scientism choose beliefs that

express their attitude of exaggerated respect for natural science. Consequently, they prefer to believe that the hard sciences are the only important and genuine fields of knowledge, and that the things studied in the hard sciences are the only things that exist. As a rough analogy, compare the probable motivation for the medieval doctrine that all things depend upon God for their existence and would instantly pop out of existence were God to stop willing them to exist. Medieval philosophers said this, along with many other implausible things, for the purpose of further glorifying God and augmenting His importance in their philosophy. Similarly, victims of scientism, with few restrictions, adopt whatever philosophical beliefs they feel most glorify science.

For a victim of scientism, ethical intuitionism is obviously unacceptable, for two reasons. First, ethics is not part of hard science. Neither physics, nor chemistry, nor biology studies such things as 'rightness'. Neither the theory of the big bang, nor quantum mechanics, nor the theory of evolution can explain why murder is wrong. The most that science might do is to explain the *causes* of human moral *attitudes*. Therefore, surely, the attitudes are all that there is. If moral facts were to exist in addition, then there would be something not studied by scientists.

Second, intuition is, putatively, not part of the scientific method. I think this is actually quite false—I think intuition is essential to science⁴—but it is widely believed to be true. The victims of scientism believe that science is purely empirical knowledge. If there were such a thing as intuition, then some knowledge would be different from scientific knowledge; therefore, surely there is no such thing as intuition. The only form of moral realism that victims of scientism find worthy of consideration is ethical naturalism, and that is because the ethical naturalists try to assimilate moral knowledge to scientific knowledge. Only if it can be shown to be 'like science' can ethics be legitimate.

9.4.5 How intuitionism became 'implausible'

The strong, widespread opposition to ethical intuitionism, then, is the result of the confluence of at least three powerful and pervasive cultural trends. Most modern intellectuals have fallen prey to cynicism, political correctness, scientism, or some combination of these attitudes, and none of these attitudes fit well with intuitionism. My contention is that this led to intuitionism's fall from favor. But we must not understand this process in a simplistic way.

First, we should not think that those who rejected intuitionism generally did so by explicitly entertaining the reasoning I have

described above; we should not think that the victims of scientism, for example, explicitly entertained the practical syllogism, 'I wish to believe only that which most glorifies science; ethical intuitionism fails to glorify science; therefore, I shall reject intuitionism'. The influence of such attitudes as scientism, cynicism, and political correctness is more subtle and insidious: these attitudes operate as *biases*, rather than explicit premises. They contaminate our judgments as to what seems 'plausible' on its face, which theories are most worth spending time investigating, which objections are 'important' and 'interesting', and so on. Thus, rather than reasoning from the premise 'Only that which glorifies science is true', victims of scientism are simply influenced to feel theories which amplify the importance of science to be 'more plausible' than those that do not. Victims of political correctness simply find theories which imply that some people are better than others 'implausible'. And so on. That is why many who hear about ethical intuitionism just consider it implausible on its face, for reasons they cannot articulate.

Of course, there could be other explanations: perhaps they find intuitionism implausible because intuitionism is, in fact, radically mistaken. But I have spent this book arguing that that is not so. Furthermore, if that were so, we would expect intuitionism to have also seemed implausible to people in many other cultures and at many different times. Instead, even anti-realists seem to admit that core tenets of intuitionism—particularly moral realism—have been assumed throughout most of the history of Western philosophy and are presupposed in ordinary moral discourse.⁵ This suggests that anyone who considers moral realism *counter-intuitive* has anomalous intuitions that call for some special explanation. It seems more likely that the relatively recent shift in metaethical intuitions away from moral realism is due to the sort of peculiar cultural trends I have been discussing, than that the metaethical intuitions of almost all the rest of humanity throughout history have been severely skewed and that only now are we seeing things objectively.

Next, we should not suppose that the causes I have mentioned are the only ones responsible for the rejection of intuitionism, nor should we assume that the same causes have operated in all people who rejected it. It is quite possible that cynicism, political correctness, and scientism could ultimately explain the popularity of anti-realism, even if most anti-realists were not themselves victims of cynicism, political correctness, or scientism. To see why this is so, notice three points: (a) That a *minority* may still constitute a *plurality*; thus, if 40 per cent of people hold theory *A*, this may be enough (provided more than two alternatives exist) for *A* to be the most widely-held theory.

(b) That people's beliefs are strongly influenced by other people; there is a strong drive towards conformity. Odd as it may seem, it is probably true that *most* people in our society endorse anti-realism only because other people do. (Such people probably endorse anti-realism at a rather shallow level, and they may also hold attitudes incompatible with anti-realism.) (c) That some people have a much greater intellectual influence than others—for instance, a professor, journalist, or artist probably influences others' philosophical beliefs more than an electrician would. Those who most influence others' philosophical ideas may be referred to as 'intellectuals'. Putting these three points together, we can see that, for moral anti-realism to have come to dominate our culture, it might have been sufficient that a sizeable minority of the intellectuals, who themselves are a small minority of society, should have succumbed to cynicism, political correctness, or scientism. The rest of society may have come to adopt anti-realism as a result of the influence of others.

I would not wish to be understood as claiming that reasons and evidence play no role in philosophical theorizing. But even if an individual accepts only those positions for which he can find plausible arguments, and accepts them on the basis of those arguments, non-rational biases may still play a decisive role in determining his belief system. To see why this is so, notice (a) that such biases may determine which positions one *looks for* arguments to support, (b) that there very often are plausible arguments for each of multiple competing theories, particularly in philosophy, and (c) that non-rational biases may affect how plausible one finds an argument. In view of points (b) and (c), a skilled philosopher who sets out looking for ways to defend a particular philosophical position will generally find some arguments that he will consider plausible (naturally, there are some limitations to this); thus, the decisive move is the one made right at the beginning, when one decides which theory to sympathetically investigate. And *that* move is typically more a result of bias than of arguments.

It goes without saying that, if I am right, anti-realist metaethical beliefs have generally been formed in an unreliable manner, through processes that are unlikely to lead to the truth. The fact that anti-realism enables one to express one's attitudes, feelings, or personality is no indication of its truth. The fact that moral realism causes some people to feel offended or hurts people's feelings constitutes no evidence against it. The fact that science is good and science does not study value is no evidence against the reality of value.

I do not expect my book to change all of this. Those who feel cynical, those who wish to glorify science, and those who feel

offended by the idea of some cultures being more right than others will, for the most part, continue to reject moral realism. If they are philosophers, they will devise clever ways of trying to work around my arguments in this book. If they are not philosophers, they will ignore the arguments. Only a few will seriously consider changing their views. That, unfortunately, is the way of philosophy.

9.5 The importance of intuitionism

I would not have written this book if I did not think the truth of intuitionism mattered. It is important in two ways. First, it is theoretically important. Intuitionists posit a realm of facts—evaluative facts—different in kind from the facts recognized by all other views, and a way of knowing—intuition—different in kind from those recognized by all other views. The dispute between intuitionists and everyone else is thus a fundamental ontological and epistemological one. It is crucial to our general understanding of the world and our place in it.

Second, it is practically—morally—important. Anti-realist theories about value undermine our moral beliefs, our moral motivation, and even our sense of the meaning of life. They undermine our moral beliefs, because—as many anti-realists themselves admit—our ordinary, common sense moral beliefs are beliefs about a putative realm of objective value properties. When we say something is morally wrong, we do not merely mean that it goes against our preferences or customs, nor do we intend our remark to be heard as a mere expression of a non-cognitive emotional reaction. Most people will rightly take anti-realist arguments as implying that all we are *entitled* to say is something about our preferences or customs, or something expressing a non-cognitive attitude, which means that our moral beliefs are unjustified.

Anti-realist theories undermine our moral motivation, because they tell us that we have no good reasons for acting morally *unless* doing so will satisfy our desires. In truth, acting morally often is not, and does not appear to us to be, the best way to satisfy our desires. Most people who become convinced of the Humean account of reasons will thus draw the conclusion that they often have no good reason to be moral. (They will not instead assume that they have good reason to be moral and thence conclude that contrary to appearances, it must be that moral behavior really does satisfy their desires.) Furthermore, on the Humean theory of motivation, no person could possibly be motivated by anything other than desires; even if you were a moral realist and mistakenly thought that certain

moral principles were objectively true and provided good reasons for action, the Humean would say, you *still* could not be motivated to act merely by those beliefs. I have argued that the Humean theory of motivation is false, and philosophers' endorsement of the theory cannot make it become true; however, telling people that they necessarily behave in a certain way has a tendency to make them behave *more* in that way than they otherwise would, provided they believe what you tell them. For instance, falsely telling people that everyone is completely selfish will tend to cause them—if they believe you—to start behaving more selfishly than they otherwise would. And falsely telling people that no one can be motivated by objective moral principles will tend to cause them—if they believe you—to try less hard to behave in accordance with objective moral principles. People have enough trouble with weakness of will and the temptations to rationalize selfish behavior, without philosophers telling them that disinterested moral concern is impossible and proclaiming all of morality a 'myth', as the title of one recent book has it.⁶

This last point assumes the truth of my account of moral motivation. If the Humean account of motivation is correct, then people already act solely in accordance with their desires; telling them the Humean theory cannot make them do so *more*. Indeed, none of what I have said in this section is evidence for intuitionism, nor is any of it my reason for endorsing intuitionism. It is only reason, given the truth of intuitionism, to think that truth is important.

Lastly, moral anti-realism undermines our sense of meaning in life, and this brings me to one of the reasons why I find anti-realism unbelievable. I think anti-realism really boils down to the view that *nothing matters*. Now, most anti-realists would deny this. They would proceed to devise interpretations of the sentence 'nothing matters' such that it means something that their theory is not committed to. They will say that 'nothing matters' expresses a non-cognitive emotional attitude that they do not in fact have; or that 'nothing matters' means that our society has no conventions for approving or disapproving of anything; or that it means that they themselves don't have any moral emotions; etc. All of this rings hollow to me. Despite what I know they would say, I think the anti-realist view is nevertheless that, in reality, nothing matters. Life has no meaning, because 'meaning' is one of those 'spooky', non-natural properties that anti-realists do not believe in. The anti-realists would perhaps say that life may still be said to have meaning, because we can *assign* it some significance, simply by taking the appropriate non-cognitive attitude towards it. But this too rings hollow. One cannot honestly just 'assign' value to things while consciously regarding that assign-

ment as merely arbitrary, and maintaining that from the objective standpoint, those things are without value. Moral values, like all beliefs, are jealous things: they contain an inherent claim to *correctness*. If I believe that *p*, I am believing that *p* is *true*; I cannot consistently recognize the negation of *p* as an equally acceptable, or equally true, belief. Likewise, if I sincerely believe *x* is good, I regard my value judgment as correct; I cannot coherently recognize an equally (or more) correct perspective which assigns no value to *x*.

Admittedly, it is possible—as subjectivists and non-cognitivists have done—to devise interpretations of evaluative discourse such that one could deny objective value and yet still say things are ‘really good’ or ‘really bad’. But as I have argued in previous chapters, these interpretations are simply false. When I say ‘*p* is true’, I do not merely mean ‘I believe *p*’—and this, *contra* the truth-relativists, is something about which there is no serious question. Analogously, when I say ‘*x* is good’, I do not merely mean ‘I value *x*’, or anything similar. In short, I think that among anti-realists, it is only the nihilists who are entirely forthright.

9.6 How I became a spooky, unscientific intuitionist

I have been a moral realist for as long as I can remember. I think the reason is roughly this: it seems to me that certain things, such as pain and suffering to take the clearest example, are bad. I don’t think I’m just making that up, and I don’t think that is just an arbitrary personal preference of mine. If I put my finger in a flame, I have a certain experience, and I can directly see something about *it* (about the experience) that is bad.⁷ Furthermore, if it is bad when I experience pain, it seems that it must also be bad when someone else experiences pain. Therefore, I should not inflict such pain on others, any more than they should inflict it on me.⁸ So there is at least one example of a rational moral principle.

But I was not always an *intuitionist*: when I first learned of the theory, in the form espoused by W. D. Ross, I thought that it rendered ethics unacceptably arbitrary. Ross had given a list of several different ‘*prima facie* duties’ that we have, such as the duty to keep promises, the duty to avoid causing harm, the duty to show gratitude for benefits given to us, and so on. Ross had no account of why these things were all duties, other than that it just seemed so to most people; nor had he any account of how to resolve conflicts between *prima facie* duties in particular cases, other than to just use one’s best judgment.⁹ It seemed to me that this rendered most moral judgments doubly arbitrary: there was arbitrariness both in the general principles

of duty themselves, and in their application to particular circumstances.

I am not sure, now, why I thought these things. If someone had asked me, 'Do you think that every belief requires an infinite series of arguments in order to be justified?' I would surely have said no. So what was 'arbitrary' about Ross' ethical views could not have been the mere fact that he advanced some claims without argument. I think I would have been satisfied, or at least less inclined to make the 'arbitrariness' objection, if Ross had stated a single ethical principle from which all other ethical principles could be logically derived—as, for example, the utilitarians do. No one makes the charge of arbitrariness against utilitarians. But this makes little sense—if a single foundational ethical principle may be non-arbitrary, why not two? Or six? Or a hundred?

At any rate, it was not the above considerations that brought me around to Ross' point of view. Instead, the turning point came when I noticed that there were *many* things I knew that I could never prove in any scientific, intersubjectively accessible way. And these were not some sort of mystical revelations, but perfectly mundane things that there was no serious doubt at all that I knew. A friend might call me on the phone and, after perhaps one second of speech, I would know who it was. She would not have to state her name or any other self-identifying information. If someone asked me how I knew who it was, I could say nothing more informative than, 'Well, it sounds like Sue'. Of course, there must be some combination of characteristics of the voice pattern that enable me to recognize it. Perhaps cognitive psychologists could figure it out. But *I* certainly couldn't tell you. Nevertheless, there is no serious doubt at all that I know Sue's voice.

Other examples of unprovable knowledge are easy to come by. Talking to a friend, I notice that he is upset about something; I couldn't tell you how I know. I couldn't give you a satisfactory definition of 'table', but I know that the object in front of me is one, and the object I'm drinking out of is not. Modern philosophers have tended to see science and mathematics as the paradigms of knowledge, and cases of unprovable knowledge as peripheral exceptions to the rule. But this, I realized, was severely skewed: unprovable knowledge is the *norm*. This is to say nothing against scientific or mathematical knowledge, but they are the exceptions—an ordinary person may live an entire life and never do one mathematical proof or scientific experiment. But each of us constantly comes to know the sorts of things in my examples above.

So Ross' reliance on exercises of intellectual judgment in individual cases, in the absence of any identifiable algorithm, does not

render his view of moral knowledge strange, in comparison with most human cognition. When we consider certain situations, such as the Trolley Car problem or the Organ Harvesting example,¹⁰ we find that we can judge certain actions to be right or wrong, even though we lack any systematic theory capable of computing the right answer in all cases. This does not render our judgments 'arbitrary', any more than my belief that I am talking to Sue on the telephone is arbitrary. It would take an absurdly skeptical disposition to declare that since I cannot specify a set of voice pattern properties by which one could identify Sue's voice, I don't know whom I am talking to.

A second important turning point occurred when I attended a lecture by Donald Davidson at Berkeley explaining his 'anomalous monism'.¹¹ Davidson's lecture concerned the relationship between mental states and brain states, but an analogous view might be taken of the relationship between moral properties and natural properties. It was Davidson's view that mental states supervene on brain states—it is impossible to have a change in one's mental state without some change in the brain—but that, nevertheless, it is not possible to pick out all the mental states of a given kind using only concepts from brain physiology. For instance, the mental state of *believing that mosquitos have small teeth* might be capable of being realized by many different brain states, which might have nothing interesting in common when described solely in brain-physiology terms. Davidson explained at length that there was no conceptual difficulty in this. For me, what was important was that the obvious fact that moral properties *depend on* natural properties does not entail that one can identify some natural property, or even a finite disjunction of natural properties, that all morally right actions have in common. So there was nothing metaphysically absurd in Ross' picture of multiple duties that have no natural feature in common—that have nothing in common other than their being duties.

With that, my main source of resistance to intuitionism—the 'arbitrariness' objection—was defused, and I was free to accept that in the moral realm, things are, after all, essentially the way they appear. I have moral intuitions, just as nearly everyone else does. They seem to be cognitions of moral truths. It seems that such things as murder, torture, and theft are really wrong—and not just because I personally don't like them. I lay no claim to infallibility, either for myself or for the human community; it is logically possible that I and the rest of humanity are radically deceived (it is also 'possible' in the same sense that we are all brains in vats). But shouldn't we *first* see whether it can be maintained that everything is more or less the way it seems, before jumping to schizoid theories about radical delusions and

errors? A plausible theory of morality cannot simply *ignore* our moral intuitions. Wouldn't it be simplest to say that the reason why we have the intuition that pain is bad is because pain is, in fact, bad, and our intuition is our awareness of that fact?

